

If he's not well-known, his buildings sure are

By Robert Campbell
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Henry N. Cobb, the new chairman of Harvard's department of architecture, is a stranger to a public that has been talking about his buildings for years.

Cobb, who takes over at Harvard July 1, designed Boston's Hancock Tower and other notable works. But he has remained relatively anonymous until now within the New York firm I.M. Pei and Partners.

Cobb will continue to practice with Pei while commuting to a pied-a-terre apartment in Cambridge to handle his new position. As chairman he succeeds Gerald M. McCue, who is moving up to dean of the School of Design.

Cobb comes to Harvard at a time when its students, like those elsewhere, are uncertain and much influenced by avant-garde ideas emanating from the fashionable architectural ateliers of New York and Princeton. Cobb, respected as both a competent practitioner and a creative thinker, hopes to use his new job to make connections.

"I think this is a particularly important moment for practicing professionals and schools to get together," he says, "because there is electricity in the air, and much of it is more focused in the schools than even in the profession. This is a kind of two-way street: It's not only that professionals can benefit teaching, but it's a real nurturing in the other direction as well."

Noting the recent, well-publicized explosion of new ideas and visual

styles in architecture, Cobb says he thinks Harvard should avoid throwing itself into any particular camp but should remain open to diversity. "Openness presents some risks," he adds. "One can slip into a kind of narcissism in which anything goes. There has to be a moral center, a shared commitment to the notion that, while usefulness is not sufficient for architecture, it is necessary."

Cobb was a founder of I.M. Pei and Partners in 1955 after several years of working with Ieh Ming Pei at the New York real estate firm of Webb and Knapp. Since then the Pei firm has won international acclaim for such works as the Hancock, the East Building of the National Gallery in Washington, the Christian Science complex and the John F. Kennedy Library. In 1968 it won the American Institute of Architects' Firm Award.

With Pei, Cobb did numerous projects including office buildings, campuses and downtown redevelopments. In Boston, besides the Hancock, he was responsible for the Harbor Towers. His current work includes a world headquarters for Johnson and Johnson, the medical supply company, in New Jersey; an office tower in Dallas; a laboratory in Texas; and a museum of art for Portland, Maine. He also has been involved in urban design projects and was largely responsible for the urban renewal plan for Boston's Government Center.

Cobb, 54, is well known to Boston, where he was born and grew up. He attended Phillips Exeter Academy,

Harvard College and the Harvard Design School. He has taught extensively at Yale and was president of the Harvard Design School alumni and a trustee of the American Academy in Rome.

Cobb is known for his mild, self-effacing, friendly personality and hesitant manner of speech — qualities that camouflage his determination and ability. His appointment is seen as a strong one for Harvard, a school that has experienced ups and downs in recent years.

As a designer, Cobb remains best known for his Hancock Tower. Faced with his client's unspoken but unmistakable desire for a building taller than the rival Prudential, Cobb realized that such a building might easily dwarf its historic neighbors in Copley Square. He responded by creating an airy, angled 60-story crystal of mirror glass, whose face reflects its surroundings, a massive structure that disguises its bulk by its seeming insubstantiality. As urban sculpture, the Hancock is generally acclaimed, although at the scale of the pedestrian it can be cold and overpowering.

During the Hancock's construction, a problem developed with the mirrored window-wall. Many of the huge panes cracked in windstorms. Eventually all 10,000 panes had to be removed and replaced. The building was also structurally reinforced to stiffen it against wind. Lawsuits over these and other construction problems are still being pursued, and for some years the Hancock's technical problems overshadowed its architectural qualities. In 1977, however, the building received a National Honor Award from the American Institute of Architects.

Cobb has gained numerous honors. In 1977 he received the Arnold W. Brunner Memorial Prize from the American Academy and Institute of Arts and Letters, given annually to an architect who has made a significant contribution to architecture as an art. He is a Fellow of the American Institute of Architects and member of the American Academy and Institute of Arts and Letters.

Robert Campbell is *The Globe's* architecture critic.